from its peak of 6,000 around the First World War to about one 1,100 only, just before the Second World War. [3]

As per the 1951 census Canada's Sikhs numbered 2,148. The Canadian government amended its immigration laws in 1951 and instituted a quota of one hundred and fifty citizens (over and above the blood relations and spouses) a year from India which was increased to 300 in 1957. With further relaxation in the immigration laws, Canada's Punjabi population rose twenty times between 1961 and 1976. [4] From the mid-1950s onwards, tens of thousands of skilled Sikhs, some highly educated, settled in Canada, especially in the urban corridor from Toronto to Windsor. As their numbers grew, they established temporary gurudwaras in every major city eastward to Montreal, with the first gurudwara in eastern Canada being made in 1965. During my stay in Canada, there were a little over 90,000 Sikhs there, a majority of whom were living in the province of British Columbia (Vancouver area) followed by Ontario (Toronto), Alberta (Calgary and Edmonton), Manitoba (Winnipeg) and Quebec (Montreal) provinces. The capital city of Ottawa had about 2,500 Sikhs.

From a total of 94,803 as per the 1981 census, the Sikh population in Canada grew by 103.2 per cent to 192,608 in the 1991 census and by 66 per cent to 319,802 in the 2001 census. The sudden increase in the growth of Sikh population in the 1980s appear to be related to political instability in Punjab, which some took advantage of by posing as political asylum seekers. As per 2011 Census (next one due in 2021), the Sikh population in Canada was 468,670, which was 1.4 per cent of the total population of Canada and 1.96 per cent of the total population of Sikhs worldwide. Even if we take an increase of 30 per cent in the Sikh population in Canada after the 2011 Census, the present population of the Sikhs in Canada should be over 600,000.

In the last Canadian parliamentary elections held in October 2019, twenty Indo-Canadians were elected to the 338-member House of Commons. Of these, nineteen are of Punjabi origin and eighteen are Sikhs. Of the eighteen Sikhs, thirteen were elected from the ruling Liberal Party, four from the Conservative Party and one from the New Democratic Party. Ten Sikh MPs are from